

CASE STUDY 1

Improving Traveller Trust & Booking Confidence

A Product-Led Capability for GDT

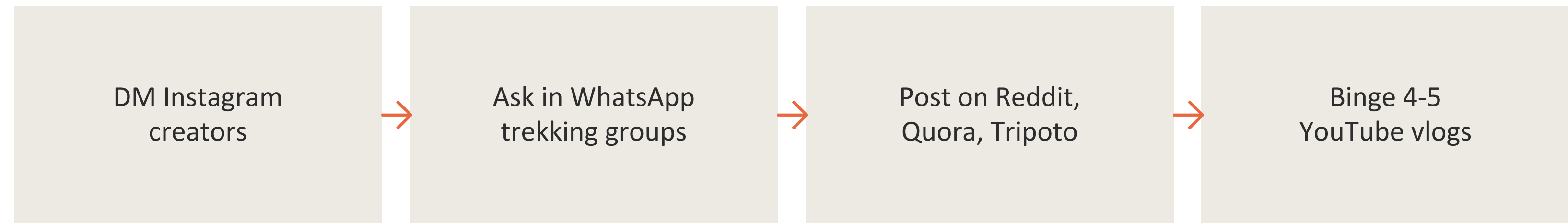
Prisha Sharma | APM Candidate Assignment

THE PROBLEM

Travellers can't verify fit.
So they leave to find trust elsewhere.

The real question isn't *"Is this a good experience?"* It's ***"Will this work for someone like me?"***

When listings fail to resolve this doubt, travellers exit the platform:



80% of millennials rely on social platforms for travel decisions. — Expedia, May 2025

USER SEGMENT

The "Almost-Booked" Intentional Traveller

WHO THEY ARE

22-35 years old, urban India, employed, digitally native

Past mass tourism. Wants treks, wellness retreats, cultural immersions, wildlife expeditions.

Spends 3-7 days between discovery and booking. High intent, high anxiety.

A bad hotel is an inconvenience. A bad trek is a wasted vacation and sore knees.

THREE UNDERLYING FEARS

Fit Fear

"Is this right for my fitness, experience, comfort level?"

Credibility Fear

"Can I trust this host to deliver what they listed?"

Reality Fear

"Will the actual experience match the listing, or is this marketing?"

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Three buckets. One gap.

ALGORITHMIC

Thrillophilia, MMT, Airbnb

Does: AI scores your profile, suggests things

Misses: Still a guess. Travellers don't trust the black box.

STRUCTURAL

Bikat, IndiaHikes

Does: Forces you to ladder up or self-select by difficulty tier

Misses: Rigid. Only works for treks. Feels like gatekeeping.

SOCIAL

Airbnb 2.0, WhatsApp, Instagram DMs

Does: Other humans tell you from their experience

Misses: Fragmented, unverifiable, slow. Lives outside the booking flow.

THE GAP: Nobody combines structured first-person evidence from past travellers with the host's lived knowledge, delivered inside one clean booking flow.

THE RECOMMENDATION

TrustKit: Two Layers, One Trust System

LAYER 1

Host's Honest Brief

Host-side radical transparency

- 1 "Who should NOT book this?"
Forces honest filtering. Builds credibility — if a host turns away wrong-fit travellers, you trust their other claims.
- 2 "What catches first-timers off guard?"
Proactive expectation-setting. Bridges the gap between listing photos and on-ground reality.
- 3 "One thing the listing doesn't fully convey"
The host's candid, personal note — weather, difficulty, pace. The human detail no algorithm can generate.

No cold-start. Works from Day 1 — no past bookings needed.

LAYER 2

Before You Book

Past-traveller pre-booking intel loop

After every trip, ONE question:

"What's the one thing you wish you'd known before booking?"

Stacks into listing

Responses form a living "Before You Book" section on every listing page.

Host curates

Hosts pin best responses and add a one-line "Host's Take" alongside.

Filtered by type

Tagged by traveller type (solo, family, first-timer) so you find people like you.

Compounds with every trip — gets better over time.

HOW THE TWO LAYERS RESOLVE THE THREE FEARS

Fit Fear

Layer 1 "who shouldn't book" + Layer 2 traveller-type tags

Credibility Fear

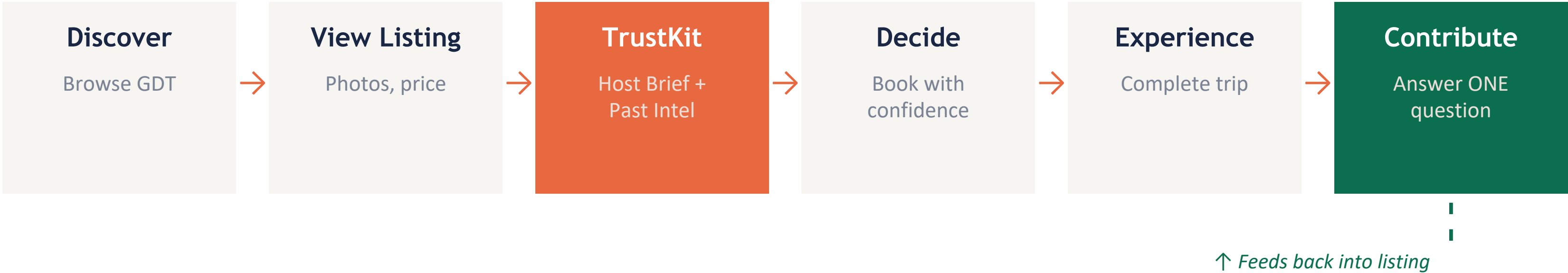
Layer 1 host transparency — willing to turn away bookings = trustworthy

Reality Fear

Layer 2 first-person evidence — real travellers, not marketing copy

WHERE TRUSTKIT SITS

Journey Flow and Three-Sided Value



VALUE TO ALL THREE SIDES

TRAVELLER	HOST / VENDOR	GDT MARKETPLACE
- Resolves fit doubt inside the platform — no more DM-ing strangers - Saves 3-7 days of external validation - Reduces post-booking regret and cancellations	- Fewer wrong-fit bookings and bad reviews - Differentiation vs. other hosts on competing platforms - Free structured product feedback from every trip	- Higher listing-to-booking conversion - Content moat that compounds — every trip makes the next listing stronger - Supply-side stickiness — hosts with TrustKit profiles have switching costs

WHY PRIORITIZE NOW

TrustKit vs. Alternatives

Factor	TrustKit	AI Fit Match	Social Features
Reach	High	High	Medium
Impact	High	Medium	Low
Confidence	High	Low	Low
Effort	4-6 weeks	Months	6-8 weeks

WHAT WE'RE NOT BUILDING (AND WHY)

-  **AI Fit Matching** Needs massive data + infra GDT doesn't have
-  **Social Features** Needs network density; thin marketplace = empty
-  **Structural Gating** Too rigid for multi-category marketplace
-  **Pre-booking Quiz** One-directional; doesn't resolve credibility fear

WHY NOW

-  GDT is early-stage: conversion is existential. TrustKit attacks the #1 blocker.
-  Competitors zig toward AI. Human transparency is counter-positioned.
-  Zero cold-start on host side. Brief works from Day 1.
-  India's \$45B experiential market (60%+ aged 18-35) rewards trust-first.

SUCCESS METRICS, RISKS & TRADE-OFFS

METRICS TIED TO THE PROBLEM

<i>Travellers leave to validate elsewhere</i>
On-platform decision rate: 30%+ reduction in external validation exits
<i>Can't verify fit on the listing page</i>
TrustKit-to-booking conversion: 15-25% lift vs. non-TrustKit listings
<i>Wrong-fit bookings waste everyone's time</i>
Cancellation rate on TK listings: 10-15% reduction within 90 days
<i>Hosts don't surface real expectations</i>
Host Brief completion rate: 60%+ of active hosts in 30 days

KEY RISKS & MITIGATIONS

Hosts resist "who should NOT book" framing
Pilot with 10-15 trusted hosts. Show cancellation reduction data after 30 days.
Low post-trip response rate
Trigger 24-48 hrs post-trip. One question only. Consider GDT credits.
TrustKit discourages bookings
Feature working as intended. Monitor net conversion (bookings minus cancellations).

TRADE-OFFS

Choosing: Human signals	Choosing: Radical honesty (incl. disqualification)	Choosing: Simplicity (1 question, 3 prompts)
Over: Scalable AI personalization	Over: Some short-term wrong-fit bookings	Over: Richer data from longer surveys

MVP: 4-6 weeks | Text-only V1 | Pilot with 15 hosts across treks, wellness, cultural | Audio/video + badges in V2